Weeks 3–4: Group Activity Worksheet

Drawing the Hidden System — Lines, Grids and Hierarchy

Tutorial Objective: Collect five visually different designs from your own device. Draw the lines, grids and alignment that hold each one together, then turn your drawings into a **system chart** that explains how each design is built.

Links to Subject Outcomes: Identify visual elements and design principles; examine grid, hierarchy, alignment and layout strategy. This is the foundation for **Assignment 1**.

Two-Week Plan

Week	Activity
3	Briefing: what is a design system? Grid vocabulary
	Part A – Collect five design items
	Part B – Line tracing (margins, columns, alignment) for all five
	Save files; progress check with the teacher
4	Recap and common mistakes
	Part C – System analysis and hierarchy map for each item
	Part D – Comparison chart and system rules
	Part E – Peer review in groups
	Part F – Reflection and Blackboard upload

Materials and Software

☐ Your phone / laptop with the five saved images
☐ **Option 1 (paper):** printouts, tracing paper, coloured fineliners (red, blue, green, orange), ruler
☐ **Option 2 (digital):** Figma, Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop or Photopea (free online) with layers
☐ This worksheet and your Visual Journal

Student Information

Field	Details
English Full Name	
Student ID	
Tutorial Class	
Peer Review Group	
Date (Week 3 / Week 4)	

Key Vocabulary (Reference)

Term	Meaning
Margin	Empty space between the content and the edge of the format
Column	Vertical division that holds content
Gutter	Space between columns or rows
Module	A single cell formed where columns and rows cross
Baseline grid	Horizontal lines that text sits on, giving vertical rhythm
Alignment axis	An invisible line that several elements line up on
Hierarchy	The order in which the eye reads elements (1st, 2nd, 3rd…)
Focal point	The element that grabs attention first

Common Grid Types

Manuscript (one block) · **Column** (2–12 columns) · **Modular** (columns + rows) · **Hierarchical** (custom zones) · **Baseline** (horizontal rhythm)

Part A: Collect Five Design Items (Week 3)

A.1 Collection Rules

1. Download or screenshot from **your own device**: photos, saved images, screenshots, apps you use or websites you visit.
2. The five items must **look clearly different** from each other. Use **at least 3 different categories**: poster · website · app screen · social media post · packaging · book or magazine cover · menu · ticket · signage · game UI
3. Each image must be **clear and high resolution** (at least 1000 px on the short side if possible).
4. Do not pick five items from the same brand.

Tip: choose at least one item you would like to study further. One of these five will become your Assignment 1 target in Weeks 7–8.

A.2 Collection Log

#	Category	Brand / Title	Source (app, site, place)	Date Saved	Why I Chose It
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					

Difference Check

In what ways do the five items look different? *(layout density, colour, image vs. text, typography, format)*

Part B: Line Tracing (Week 3)

B.1 Colour Code (use the same code for all five items)

Colour	What to Draw
Red	Format edge and **margins**
Blue	**Columns, rows and gutters** (the grid)
Green	**Alignment axes**: lines where several elements line up
Orange	**Shape blocks**: outline every text block, image and button as a simple shape
Black numbers	**Reading order** ①②③… (hierarchy)
Star ★	**Focal point**

B.2 Step-by-Step Tracing Procedure

Repeat these steps for **each** of the five items.

Step	Action	☐
1	Place the image on the canvas (digital: lower opacity to 50% and lock the layer; paper: tape tracing paper on top).	☐
2	**Red:** draw the outer frame, then find the margins by looking for where content stops near each edge.	☐
3	**Blue:** find repeating left edges of text and images, then draw columns. Measure gutters and check whether they are equal.	☐
4	**Blue:** look for repeating horizontal positions, then draw rows or a baseline grid if present.	☐
5	**Green:** draw every alignment axis (left, centre, right, top). Extend lines across the whole format.	☐
6	**Orange:** reduce every element to a simple shape (rectangle, circle, triangle).	☐
7	**Numbers:** number the elements in the order your eye reads them. Mark the focal point ★.	☐
8	**Measure:** write margin and gutter sizes (px or mm), and the ratio of the largest to the smallest text.	☐
9	Hide the original image and check that the line drawing alone still shows the structure.	☐

B.3 Tracing Progress Tracker

Item #	Margins	Grid	Alignment	Shape blocks	Reading order	Measurements	Done
1	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

End of Week 3 progress check (teacher's initials): _____

Problems I need to solve before Week 4:

Part C: System Analysis (Week 4)

C.1 System Analysis — Item 1

Aspect	Analysis
Format & proportion *(size, ratio e.g. 4:5, 16:9, A-series)*	
Grid type & number of columns / rows	
Margins *(top / bottom / left / right; equal or not?)*	
Gutters	
Main alignment *(left / centre / right / mixed)*	
Hierarchy (1st → 2nd → 3rd read) & what creates it *(size, colour, position, contrast)*	
Visual elements used *(dot, line, shape, space, colour, texture)*	
Design principles *(movement, balance, emphasis, unity)*	
Typography *(number of typefaces / sizes / weights)*	

C.2 System Analysis — Item 2

Aspect	Analysis
Format & proportion	
Grid type & number of columns / rows	
Margins	
Gutters	
Main alignment	
Hierarchy (1st → 2nd → 3rd read) & what creates it	
Visual elements used	
Design principles	
Typography	

C.3 System Analysis — Item 3

Aspect	Analysis
Format & proportion	
Grid type & number of columns / rows	
Margins	
Gutters	
Main alignment	
Hierarchy (1st → 2nd → 3rd read) & what creates it	
Visual elements used	
Design principles	
Typography	

C.4 System Analysis — Item 4

Aspect	Analysis
Format & proportion	
Grid type & number of columns / rows	
Margins	
Gutters	
Main alignment	
Hierarchy (1st → 2nd → 3rd read) & what creates it	
Visual elements used	
Design principles	
Typography	

C.5 System Analysis — Item 5

Aspect	Analysis
Format & proportion	
Grid type & number of columns / rows	
Margins	
Gutters	
Main alignment	
Hierarchy (1st → 2nd → 3rd read) & what creates it	
Visual elements used	
Design principles	
Typography	

Part D: The System Chart (Week 4)

D.1 Comparison Matrix

Item	Grid Type	Columns	Alignment	Focal Point	Density *(sparse / balanced / dense)*	Main Principle
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						

What do the most effective items have in common?

D.2 Write the "System Rules"

*Imagine you must give instructions to another designer so they can make a **new** design in the same system. Write 3–5 rules per item, like a recipe.*

Example: "1. Use a 6-column grid with 40 px margins. 2. Headline spans 4 columns, top-left. 3. One full-bleed image fills the bottom half. 4. All text aligns to column 1."

Item	System Rules (3–5)
1	
2	
3	
4	
5	

D.3 Final System Chart Layout

Assemble your **finished system chart** as a set of pages:

Page	Content
Cover	Title, name, student ID, thumbnails of all five items
Pages 1–5	One page per item: original image ↔ line drawing side by side, colour-code legend, measurements, hierarchy numbers, system rules
Page 6	Comparison matrix (D.1) and key findings

Sketch your page layout plan below *(use a grid, as this is a design job too!)*

Part E: Peer Review (Week 4)

Swap system charts with one classmate. Check their work and fill in the table for them.

Check	Yes / No	Comment
Five items, at least 3 categories, clearly different		
Colour code used consistently		
Margins, grid and alignment are accurate		
Reading order is believable		
System rules are clear enough to follow		

Reviewer name: _____ Most insightful finding:

Part F: Reflection

Which item had the most hidden structure? What surprised you?

Which item seemed to have *no* grid? Is it really grid-free, or does it use a different kind of system?

Which item would you like to study further for Assignment 1, and why?

Blackboard Submission

Upload Checklist

☐ Collection log (A.2) with all five sources
☐ Five line drawings (original + overlay side by side)
☐ Five system analysis tables (Part C)
☐ Comparison matrix and system rules (Part D)
☐ Peer review (Part E) and reflection (Part F)

File Requirements

Item	Requirement
Format	One combined PDF *(the finished system chart)*
File Name	`W03-04_[EnglishFullName]_[StudentNumber].pdf`
Location	Blackboard → SSHD2382 → Weeks 3–4 → System Chart
Deadline	Before the start of the Week 5 tutorial

Keep your editable files (Figma / PSD / AI). You will extend this work in Weeks 7–8 for Assignment 1.

Additional Notes

References & Resources

Record the source of every design item (brand, URL or app, date accessed) and any reference about grids you used: